



FIRST DECK LANDING

On August 2, 1917, pilot E.H. Dunning made the first successful landing on the deck of a moving ship. He was flying a Sopwith Pup, a popular, highly maneuverable airplane. An unsuccessful attempt five days later ended in his death.

of the war, an ocean liner was converted into HMS *Argus*, the first true aircraft carrier. The funnel was hidden away at the back of the ship, allowing a long, unobstructed flight deck. British naval commanders planned to use *Argus* for a Pearl Harbor-style strike against the German fleet in port. Modern naval aviation had been born.

the economic life of Germany and its war industries by methodical and repeated action against principal industrial cities..." In 1918 the Allies had the de Havilland-designed Airco D.H.9 and excellent Breguet Br.14 as day bombers and the Handley Page O/400 and Caproni biplanes and triplanes as night bombers. The Handley Page, although nothing like as big as the German R-planes, could carry a maximum bombload of 2,000lb (900kg), and formed the backbone of the Independent Force. Other heavy bombers, including the French Farman Goliath and the British Vickers Vimy, were under construction in 1918 but arrived too late to see service.

Lesson in terror

In the summer and fall of 1918, formations of up to 40 Allied bombers flew raids deep into Germany. Predictably, bad weather and unreliable aircraft limited the effectiveness of the bomber offensive. But civilians in cities such as Frankfurt and Mannheim were taught the terror of air-raids that had already been experienced by inhabitants of Paris and London. Allied airmen were always under orders to aim for precise targets, such as factories or communications centers. But Allied political leaders were eager to affect civilian morale. The British Secretary of State for air, William Weir, told Hugh Trenchard, the commander of the Independent Force, not to be scrupulous in respect for civilian life: "If I were you," he wrote, "I would not be too exacting as regards accuracy in bombing railway stations in the middle of towns. The German is susceptible to bloodiness, and I would not mind a few accidents due to inaccuracy."

In fact, the air commanders were generally more sceptical about strategic bombing than the politicians. Trenchard knew he was supposed to use his force to bomb German cities and factories, but more often he directed it against tactical objectives such as airfields and communications centers behind the front. The same is true of US General Billy Mitchell. Both Trenchard and Mitchell later became advocates of strategic bombing, but they devoted themselves in the last months of the war to the tactical use of airpower.

The evidence of World War I was that, at current levels of technology, strategic bombing could neither seriously disrupt industrial production nor

"It is probable that future war will be conducted by a special class, the air force, as it was by the armored knights of the Middle Ages."

BRIGADIER GENERAL WILLIAM
"BILLY" MITCHELL
WINGED DEFENSE, 1924



FIRST INDEPENDENT AIR FORCE

This recruiting poster invites volunteers to join the Royal Air Force (RAF), the world's first independent air force. Created by combining Britain's army and navy air arms in April 1918, the RAF was intended to prioritize the protection of Britain against air attack and promote the strategic bombing of enemy factories and cities.

significantly weaken a population's will to fight. Bombing was costly and inaccurate. Its chief positive effect lay in forcing the enemy to divert resources to air defense.

The building and operation of large bomber aircraft was nonetheless an important step in the progress of aviation. Bomber aircrews had accumulated extensive experience of long-distance flight and night flying, and the large aircraft they flew carrying bombs could, with relatively small modifications, carry passengers or freight instead. Strategic bombing in World War I helped pave the way for the development of commercial aviation – as well as the devastation of Dresden, Tokyo, and Hiroshima.